

BONE STORIES - ACTIVITY 4

Facilitator guide

One bone, many lives

Guide to conducting an investigation into the possible uses of an object without announcing a definitive function.

TYPE
Facilitator guide

AUDIENCE
Supervising adults

DURATION
45-75 mins

VERSION
Pilot 1.0

Cautious prototype - objects A to E and their instructions remain to be integrated.

1. In brief

The students describe an object without attributing a use to it, formulate at least two hypotheses, choose the clues that support them then list the information necessary to decide between them. Cards A to E are templates: the activity becomes fully usable after adding a validated corpus.

2. Objectives

- Distinguish observation, hypothesis, interpretation and verification.
- Describe material, shape, dimensions and visible traces.
- Propose several possible uses from clues.
- Understand the role of the archaeological and documentary context.

3. Expected success

Successful

Two hypotheses are linked to clues and to means of verification.

In progress

The hypotheses are distinct, but the clues remain imprecise.

To resume

The function is announced as certain from the first observation.

4. Duration and material

Context	Duration	Material
Class	45-75 mins	Sheet, A-E cards, photographs or validated replicas.
Museum	30-60 mins	Object in display, reproduction or manipulatable object authorized.

5. Quick preparation

À PRÉPARER

Select one to five documented objects. Complete the cards without writing a function as a title. Keep context data hidden until the verification phase. Adapt the protocol to the rules of the institution.

À DIRE

“Start with what is visible. A hypothesis is a proposition to be tested, not a certain answer. »

6. Detailed procedure

Time	Adult action	Student action	Purpose
5 mins	Present the object without function.	Write a first impression.	Bring out initial ideas.
10 mins	Temporarily ban common words.	Describe material, shape, traces, dimensions.	Install observation.
15 mins	Ask for at least two hypotheses.	Link each to clues.	Open multiple interpretations.
10 mins	Distribute validated context data.	Confirm, qualify or dismiss leads.	Test assumptions.
10 mins	Conduct a collective conclusion.	Classify established, plausible and unknown.	Conclude with caution.

7. Questions and reminders

Observe

- What can you measure?
- What traces are visible?
- What does this view not show?

Check

- What context would decide between the hypotheses?
- Which reference object to compare to?
- What analysis would be useful?

8. Responses or expected elements

No A-E function is expected before integrating the corpus. A successful production contains an independent description, at least two hypotheses, the associated clues, an objection or limit and a means of verification: context of discovery, traces of use, typological comparison, analysis of material, measurement or textual source.

9. Differentiation

Need	Adaptation
Help	Work on a single object and provide vocabulary labels.
Lighten the writing	Classify "I observe/I suppose/I verify" cards.
Go deeper	Compare two records and discuss what changes with provenance.

10. Museum adaptation

Choose an object adapted to the institution and its actual collections. Observation can be done in the window; a photograph or replica is a possible variation but does not entirely replace the original. Manipulation is only considered if the object can be handled, if the museum rules authorize it and according to the conservation protocol.

11. Quick assessment

Highlight in a conclusion an observation, a hypothesis and a means of verification. Evaluate the ability to change your mind when the context brings a new clue.

12. Common mistakes

À NE PAS AFFIRMER

Do not assert that a knucklebone was necessarily used for playing, predicting or counting. Do not announce an undocumented museum validation. Do not present a modern digital adaptation as a historical reconstruction.

- Name the object before describing it.
- Keep only one hypothesis.
- Confusing resemblance and same usage.
- Ignore discovery context.

13. Sources and limits

The support transposes an archaeological investigation approach: observation, formulation of hypotheses, comparison with the context and comparison. The five Metropolitan Museum of Art images documented as provisional in the redesign are excluded from the PDFs. The coding game is a contemporary extension, not proof of ancient use.

14. Current status and remaining validations

À VÉRIFIER

Templates and method ready for adult testing. Before a student session, integrate documented A-E objects, check notices and rights, establish the information revealed at each stage and have the corpus validated by scientific and museum managers.

Print plan

Each student: student sheet.

Each group: one to five completed object cards.

Adult: guide, correction and complete instructions.

Cutting: single-sided cards, 120-160 g paper.

Traceability : **Activity page, updates and online credits.**